Articles, determiners and agreement

Understand it

Articles are small but frequent, so errors with them add up. Ask three questions for every noun: Is it countable? Singular or plural? General or specific?

Agreement means the verb matches its subject. Long subjects and collective nouns cause most errors.

The rules

- a / an for one unspecific countable thing; the for something specific or already mentioned or unique; no article for plurals and uncountables in general.
- General statements: no article. Education is important. Children need love.
- Subject and verb must agree: The number of students IS rising. A number of students ARE late. Everyone IS; people ARE.
- Countable: many, few, a number of. Uncountable: much, little, an amount of. Uncountable nouns: advice, information, research, equipment, traffic, knowledge.

All the words and forms you need

a / an	one of many, first mention, jobs (She is a nurse)
the	specific, already mentioned, unique (the internet, the environment), superlatives, rivers, seas, plural countries (the USA)
No article	general plural and uncountable nouns (Children need love), most countries, meals, sports, languages
Uncountable nouns	advice · information · research · equipment · knowledge · traffic · evidence · furniture · homework · accommodation
Singular verb	The number of … is · Everyone is · Each student has · News is · Mathematics is
Plural verb	A number of … are · People are · The police are · Most of the students are

Where you use it

Writing: Articles and agreement are the most common grammar errors at band 6.5. Check every noun at the end.

Speaking: Do not stop speaking to think about an article; fix it in the next sentence.

Reading: The word the shows that the writer means something specific, already known or already mentioned.

More examples

- Education is the key to a better life.

- The education I received was excellent.
- A number of students are absent today.
- The number of tourists is rising.
- She gave me some useful advice.
- Research shows that sleep improves memory.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ The pollution is a big problem. (general)	✓ Pollution is a big problem.
✗ She gave me many advices.	✓ She gave me a lot of advice.
✗ The number of cars are rising.	✓ The number of cars is rising.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What advice would you give a new student?
2. Where do you get information about the news?
3. Is the internet good for children?
4. What is the most useful thing you have at home?
5. How many people in your family speak English?

Writing practice

Correct the 5 errors: The pollution is a big problem in the most cities. Government have to give an informations to people about a public transport.

Practice

1. Add an article or none: ___ sun rises in ___ east.

2. Add an article or none: ___ education is important.

3. Choose: (Much / Many) information is online.

4. Choose: The number of tourists (is / are) growing.

5. Correct: He gave me an useful advice.

6. Correct: Research show that sleep matters.

Answers

1. The; the
2. (no article)
3. Much
4. is
5. He gave me some useful advice.
6. Research shows that sleep matters.